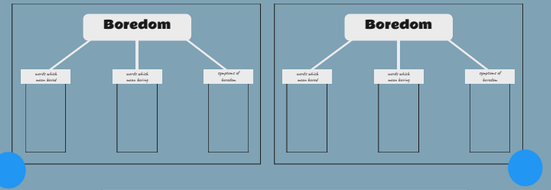
1 Work with a partner. Make a list of five situations that make people very bored. Rank them from most boring (5) to least boring (1).

Listen to and make notes on the speakers' boring experiences 1-7.

Compare your notes with a partner. Which of the situations have you experienced? How bored did they make you feel?

2 With a partner, complete the diagram with the phrases in the box.

bored to death | *bored with* | *come out* | *can't sit still* | *dull* | *fed up with* | *feel desperate to escape*
your mind wanders | *yawn* | *uninteresting* | *tired of* | *repetitive* | *lose concentration* | *have had enough of*



3 Work in small groups and discuss the questions.

1. *What is the most boring aspect of your job or studies?*
2. *Which would you imagine are the most boring aspects of these jobs?*
   - *police detective*
   - *airline pilot*
   - *writer*

4 Read the article and match paragraphs 1-4 to headings a-e. There is one heading you do not need.

a: The dangers of feeling bored
b: How it feels to be bored
c: The benefits of boredom
d: Let yourself be bored!
e: A complicated emotion

The fascinating topic of boredom

1. _____

Boredom. We've all experienced it: that unpleasant feeling of being **trapped** in a situation we're desperate to escape from, that **desire** to fall asleep in a dull lecture or meeting, that need to get out and do something on a rainy day.

2. _____

Boredom has become a fascinating topic for academics in recent years, and studies have shown it is experienced more frequently and intensely than anxiety, anger or enjoyment. They have also shown there are not one, but five types of boredom, ranging from a calm, relaxed type of boredom to a more harmful kind. Find out about the five boredom types here.

3. _____

But according to one major study, boredom can also be good for us: the study shows that after experiencing boredom we are keen to do meaningful things like giving blood or giving money to charity. Experts believe boredom is nature's way of telling us it's time to get up and do something. In the same way that fear has the purpose of steering us away from dangerous activity, boredom **steers** us away from useless activities. In other words, it can be a very useful emotion.

4. _____

However, in today's electronic world it's rare to have nothing to do. There's always something to keep our minds **occupied**. Time waiting in a bus queue, for example, is often spent checking emails or playing games on our phones. Some people worry that nowadays we can no longer stand the thought of being bored and are no longer **capable of** doing nothing. We need to be constantly entertained. Should we instead welcome the opportunity to get bored sometimes, to let our thoughts settle and give unusual ideas a chance to form?

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5 Match words in bold in the article in exercise 4 to definitions.

trapped	able to do something
desire	unable to escape
steers	a strong wish
occupied	busy doing something
capable of	moves something in a particular direction

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1. *According to the writer, why can boredom be seen as useful? Do you agree?*
2. *Do you think we find it harder to deal with boredom than we used to? Why/Why not?*

6 Find the words in the box in the article in exercise 5 and add them to the correct list in the Grammar focus box.

GRAMMAR FOCUS other uses of -ing and infinitive with to

- ing form	*infinitive with to*
1. adjectives + preposition + -ing form. *e.g. fed up with, tired of.* 1. _____ of I'm **tired of doing** the same thing every day. **2. nouns + preposition + -ing form.** e.g. the chance of, difficulty in, a feeling of, the idea of, the purpose of, the 2. _____ of, **a way of** I hate the **idea of having** nothing to do. **3. before, since, while,** 3. _____ + **-ing form.** I've not been bored **since changing** my job.	**4. adjectives + infinitive with to,** e.g. about, desperate, easy, likely, 4. _____ , **surprised, rare, willing** How long are you **willing to wait?** **5. nouns + infinitive with to,** e.g. decision, desire, need, motivation, 5. _____ , **plan** She made a **decision to retire.** **6. anything, anyone, anywhere,** 6. _____ etc. and **something + infinitive with to** I need **something to do.**

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6 Read the article, ignoring the gaps. Which types) of boredom do you experience?

The five types of boredom

'Indifferent boredom' is the boredom you feel while 1) _____ (watch) a boring TV programme, for example. It is a pleasant feeling which gives you the opportunity 2) _____ (enjoy) a quiet, a hard day's work.

'Calibrating boredom' is when your mind wanders from the present moment 3) _____ (think) about the 4) _____ (do) something different but not the motivation 5) _____ (act) on them.

'Searching Boredom' is when you have fed up with 6) _____ (have) nothing to do and actively search for something 8) _____ (occupy) yourself. This can result in risky or illegal behaviour, but also creativity.

'Apathetic boredom' is caused by feeling trapped in a situation. You have a desire 7) _____ (do) something but can't because you're stuck, e.g. in a boring job or relationship.

'Apathetic boredom' is similar to depression. This is the most worrying boredom type. You have no interest in 9) _____ (try) anything new and are incapable of 9) _____ (find) enjoyment in life.

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